The Cleveland Museum of Art's Currently Under Curation: A participatory research project

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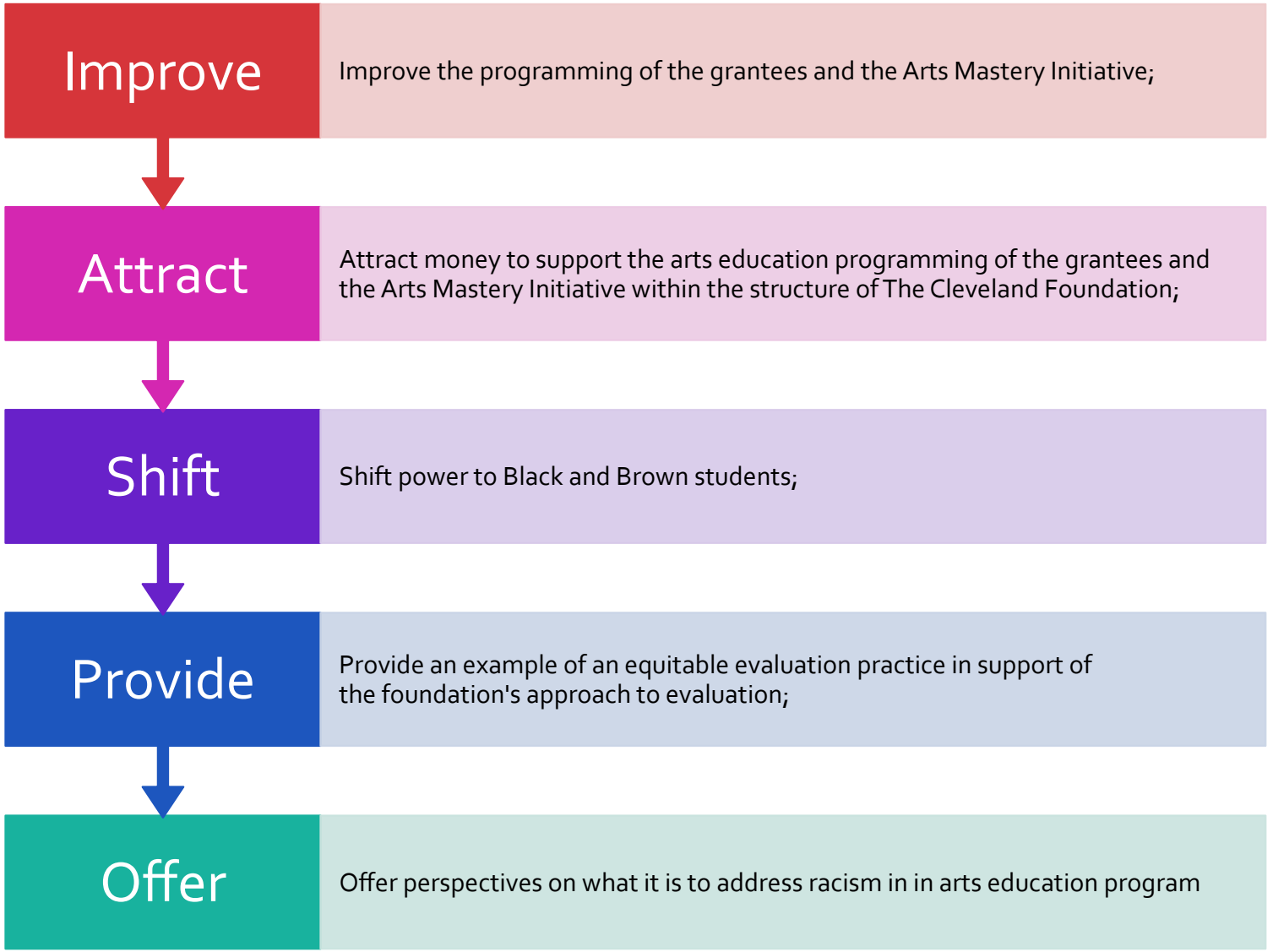
Project Background

This Reflection and Action Project (RAP), so named to highlight Paulo Freire's frame of collective observation and engagement in "Pedagogy of the Oppressed", rather than what felt to be the more judgmental frame of "evaluation" , was conducted over the fall of 2020 through the summer of 2021. In this process, "Currently Under Curation" participants, Cullen Jackson Freeman, Maya Peroune and Deonta Steele as well as staff members Sabine Kretzschmar, Sydney Kreuzmann, and Darius Steward, worked with Justin Laing of Hillombo LLC to draft the research purpose and interview protocol that would be the basis of the interviews that was our method of data collection.

Method: Utilization Focused Evaluation

This particular Reflection and Action Project was conducted as a part of a larger RAP in support of the Cleveland Foundation's Arts Mastery Initiative, a program intended to give "Cleveland children access to high-quality arts programs in their neighborhoods by partnering with organizations to deliver year-round, mastery level arts programs that allow youth to develop qualities they need in adulthood." The project used a "Utilization Focused Evaluation Method" in which stakeholders define at the outset the intended uses of the evaluation. Participants defined the general uses of this overall project at its inception in the fall of 2019. In the fall and winter of 2020, CMA and Hillombo LLC defined the research purpose and the hypothesis of change we would explore and in the spring and summer of 2021, Cullen, Maya and Deonta conducted all and analyzed some of the interviews that provide the data for this Reflection. Justin Laing, Etana Laing, Keith Jamison and Ebony Ross then coded all of the interviews with Justin creating the analysis that follows.

Intended Uses of this Reflection and Action Project



How does this project meet the intended uses?

This project has attempted to meet the use of "program improvement" by coding the interviews that were conducted and reflecting on them looking for themes in the context of the research purpose and the goals of the Arts Mastery Initiative. The interviews have been coded such that they are searchable along the lines of “reasons to stay engaged”, “quality program characteristics” and “places to improve” and they can be used to help make the case to both strengthen and support the programming of the Cleveland Museum of Art in order to meet the use of attracting dollars to the program. The "shifting power to youth racialized as Black or Brown" was met, at least in part, with the paying of young people a stipend to help design the research purpose, collect and interpret data and with the key product being coded vignettes of the interviews so that youth voices can be heard directly. In order to meet the use of providing an example of equitable evaluation, we have used the Equitable Evaluation Framework chiefly employing its guidance to place significant attention on the foundation i.e. The Cleveland Foundation.

Research Purpose

To increase our understanding of what might draw Black and Brown young creatives to attend museum programming and how we might influence both the CMA and the Cleveland Foundation to be more focused on quality of interaction than quantity of interactions.

Hypothesis of Change to be Explored in this research

If the CMA's CUC program clearly spoke to the desires, needs and aspirations of Black and Brown young creatives and we were able to engage CMA and Cleveland Foundation leadership in conversations about attendance and impact goals such that these factors did not figure so prominently in our planning conversations, then the program would have a more transformative relationship with Black and Brown young creatives, would improve the culture of CMA and its relationship to Black and Brown communities, and would be a more enjoyable place to work and create.

Sample

The sample consisted of 6 CMA participants, 3 staff members and 5 non-participants. 10 of 11 of the young people were racialized as Black or Latin American and all of the staff members were racialized as White.



This Report

This report includes the research purpose for this project as well as the hypothesis of change framing this research and the guiding questions, all of which served as the basis of the interview guide that can be seen here and served as a guide for the semi-structured interviews conducted by Cullen, Maya and Deonta, as well the interpretation of data. We provide reflections on what this data could mean for program design by looking at key codes and how they appear in data, specifically the areas of "reasons to stay engaged", "quality programming characteristics" and "places to improve". The code book, which can be seen here, has a complete listing of codes as well as the number of times each one was seen in the data and can be explored and searched in the Coded Vignette Compendium, which can be seen here. Finally, we close with concluding thoughts based on our review of the data. However, in keeping with the participatory aspiration of this project, this data is presented in a way that it will best serve as a basis for our conversation and analysis by The CMA staff.

Limits of this research

As was named by CMA staff in our process, just over half of the youth participants are CMA participants and we want to emphasize this is not an evaluation of the program, but rather an exploration into quality youth program characteristics and some connections to CMA structures. Hopefully, this report provides some ideas that can inform the design of programming, but getting the right sample for this project was a challenge and we all would have liked for the data set to have been a little deeper.

"Reasons for Enrolling"

Two dimensions that are fairly straight-forward in terms of why young people enroll in programming are “welcoming atmosphere” and “thoughtful teaching strategies” and there was nothing in the interviews of youth participants that suggested these were not already clearly held values of the staff.

Reflections

Looking at the learnings in relation to specific "codes" or dimensions in the data.

“Reasons to stay engaged”

Ranging from “experiencing feelings of success” to “having a clear objective” to “providing participants with food” to “high quality instruction”, we heard 20 different comments about why young people stay engaged in programs. In thinking about the CUC program, we do see how the CUC employs these characteristics already in holding a final exhibit curated by young people and in the design of its sessions but we include a few comments on this dimension to provide further examples.

Reasons to stay engaged: *feelings of success*

"I'm one of those people, the way I connect to things, is if, like, I am good at it. If that makes sense."

"I dunno, for me to stay engaged and like also like to have, like, to see like progress being made on something, I feel like that keeps me coming back to your project. Cause I feel like if I'm putting energy into something I want to see something continuing to grow."

"Reasons to disengage"

There were not many surprises in terms of why students disengage ranging from losing a sense of community or staff treating students rudely, but one interviewee focused on White and hetero normative culture as a major turn off as well as tokenization. In light of CMA's predominantly White staff this felt like a potential risk area or an area that could put an inordinate pressure on Black and Queer staff to make such a student feel comfortable. As museum education training seems to rely heavily on White Western culture as norm, and we noted several times the code “reproduction of White group dominance: Euro culture as norm in its non-naming”, we are curious what kinds of conversations staff and students could have about the topic of disrupting White normative and heteronormative cultures.

Quality Program Characteristics

The top 4 cited criteria for a quality program were: “variety”, “a place to build relationships”, “peer group that wants to excel” and “influences a student’s approach to art”. Examples of how students spoke about those dimensions follow.

Quality Program Characteristics: *Variety*

"We kind of went and kind of deep dived into different elements and how to combine them. Like, we used photoshop and combined them with actual, like, paint and watercolors and NG Cuff. We did a lot of screenwriting and moved on to making our own films and helping producing filming and stuff like that. I really liked the getting to do something different…"

"I don't like when things get repetitive, because then that gets boring to me. I don't like doing things I've already done before kind of so that was like. In general, I just don't like it."

Quality Program Characteristics: *A Place to Build Relationships*

"I think really getting to know people, like including instructors. Cause I feel like that makes me more connected to like the program and the people overall."



"I think it should just be surrounded with people that love the art for the history for how, like, art is always getting renewed, so I feel like it should be some artists that are more like old school and some more like modern. And, yeah, just people that actually want to go for learning and not just necessarily compensation for, like, money."



"Everybody seemed like passionate about what they were doing and like really ready to engage with each other and, like passionate about their own artwork. That made a really interesting, like, group of people to work together."

Quality Program Characteristics:
Peer group that wants to excel

Places to improve: *deepen the instruction of the art*

"I don't know. I think maybe just like some more time to plan and like, um, I don't know, like maybe a little more like. Having like the educators, like initiate like ways to go about things, because sometimes I felt like a little bit stuck. But yeah, overall I was happy about like how things went."

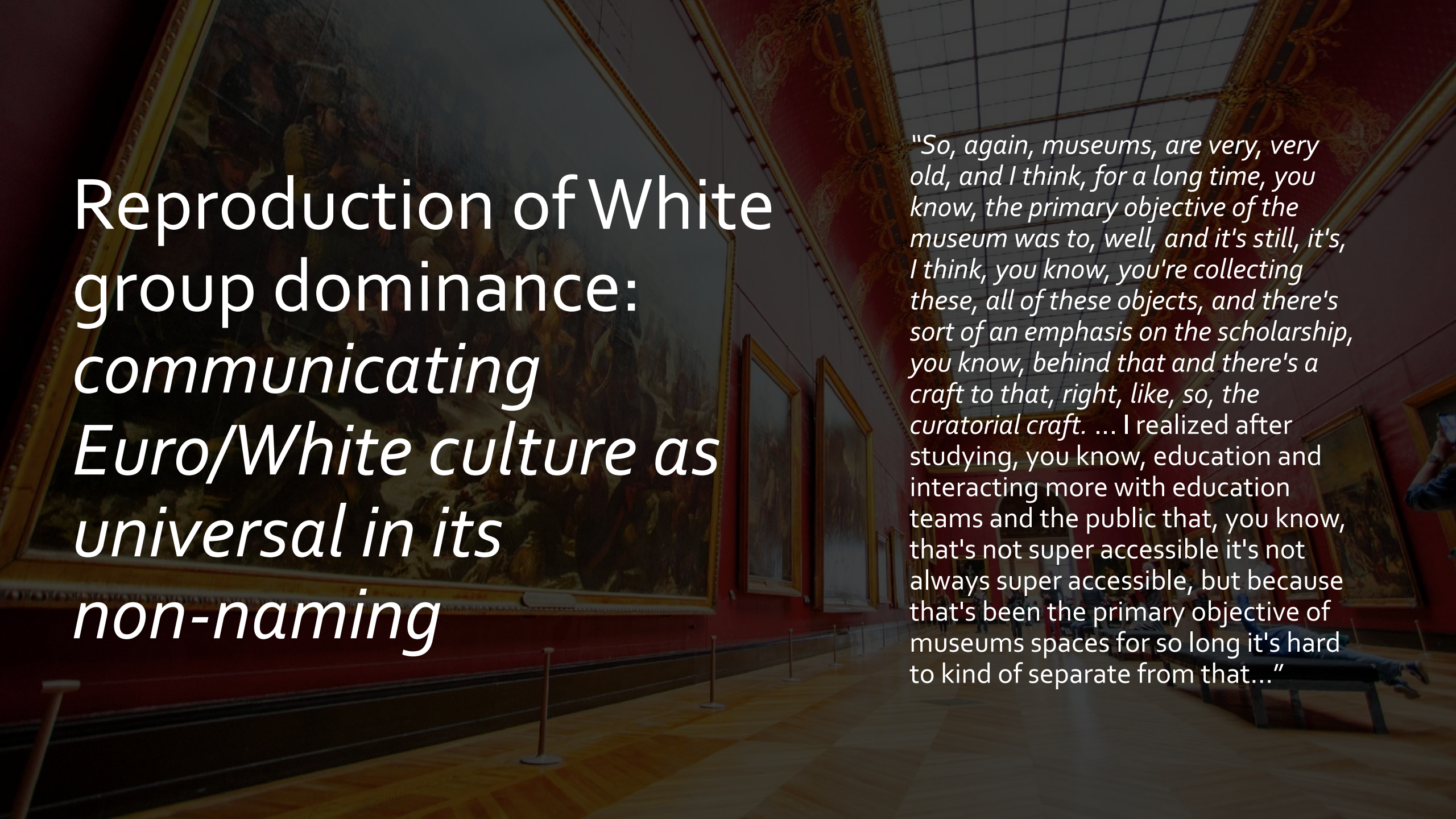
"I think maybe a little more structure. It might be beneficial. Like, I know people have like different ways that they work and things like that. so it's always kind of tricky to find that balance. Um, but I dunno. I feel like there are some times when like, deadlines weren't being met and things like that. So I feel like a little more structured might be beneficial."

"I think that I didn't really relate to it (the art) very much I enjoyed looking at it, but we didn't go very much deep or at least maybe I wasn't there enough to really connect with the artwork itself, if anything, I was really just as well as involved in the organizing of it, but I don't think that I was able to learn very much about the printing press that we got the prints from or the artists, or much about the prints themselves."



Alignment with Cleveland Foundation Strategy: Racial Equity

As a means of exploring the topic of racial equity and arts education, we took a code from the antiracist discourse analysis of TA van Dijik "reproduction of White group dominance through text and talk" and tried to see how this might appear across the Arts Mastery Initiative data set. We noticed that in the case of CMA that staff would rarely name the racial orientation of the field, their own training or background and yet the Whiteness of the organization seemed fairly visible to non-Museum employees. In this way, we thought, the non naming served to normalize Whiteness.



Reproduction of White group dominance: *communicating Euro/White culture as universal in its non-naming*

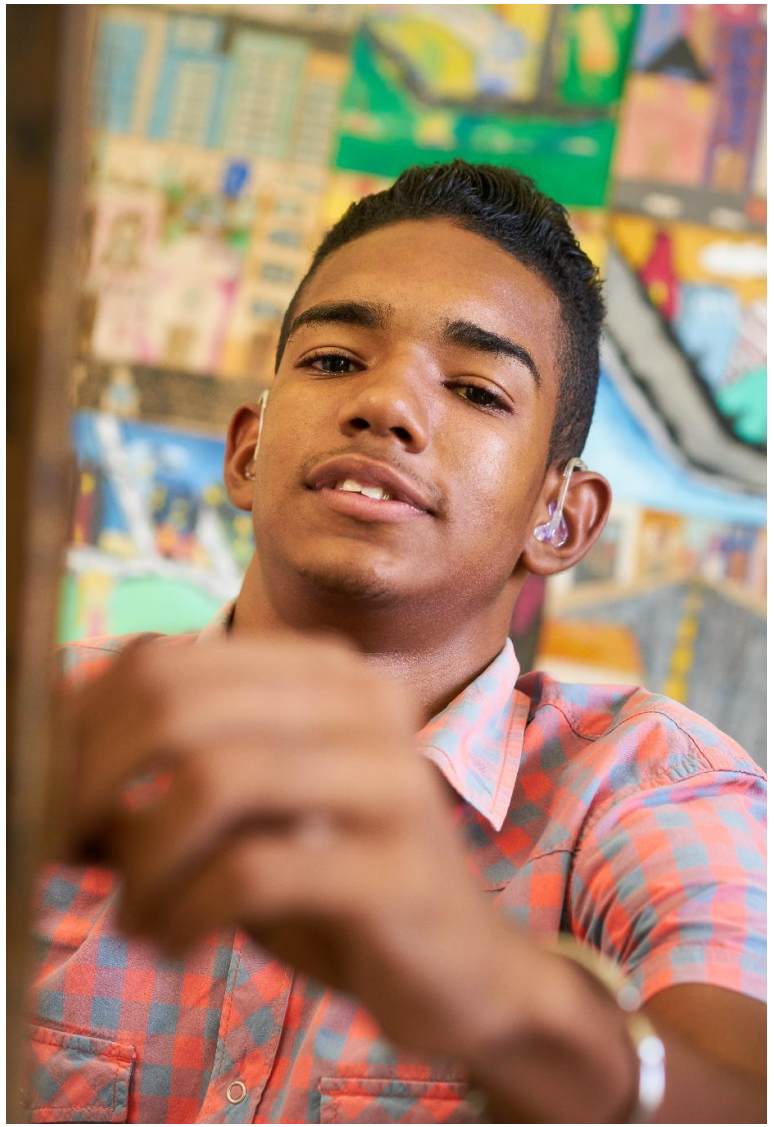
"So, again, museums, are very, very old, and I think, for a long time, you know, the primary objective of the museum was to, well, and it's still, it's, I think, you know, you're collecting these, all of these objects, and there's sort of an emphasis on the scholarship, you know, behind that and there's a craft to that, right, like, so, the curatorial craft. ... I realized after studying, you know, education and interacting more with education teams and the public that, you know, that's not super accessible it's not always super accessible, but because that's been the primary objective of museums spaces for so long it's hard to kind of separate from that..."

The Museum is not alone in the ways it is silent on Whiteness

While we want to offer the view that the non-naming of Whiteness helps to normalize, center and invisiblize it in arts discourse, we want to point out that the Arts Mastery Initiative's theory of change is silent on race nor does it name racism as a source for the need for the program in the first place. As "color-blindness" is one of the ways that Whiteness can show up as a frame, we have to draw attention to the AMI's grantmaking strategy, primarily, and this particular part of CMA programming as largely derivative of that strategy.

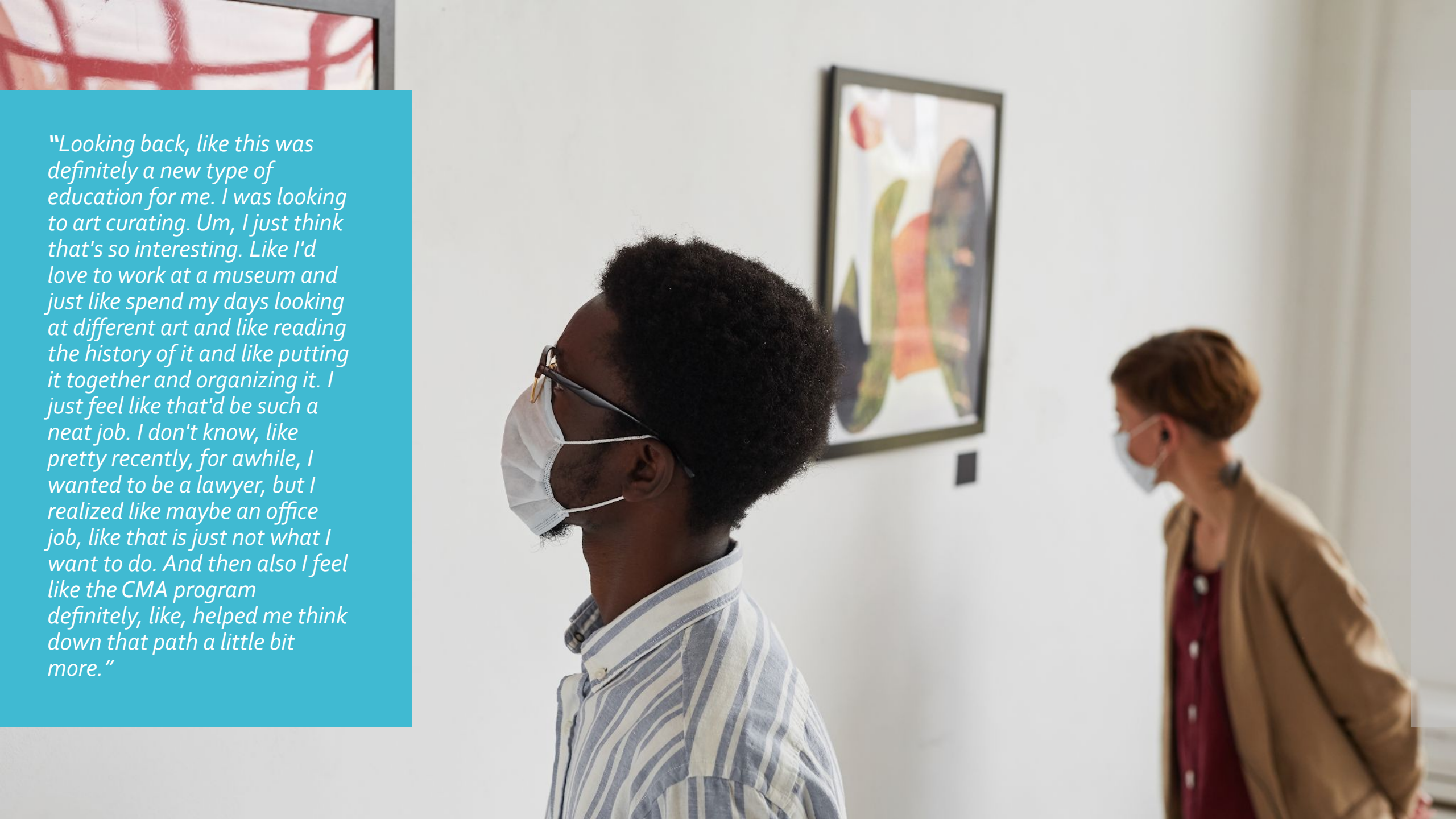
Alignment with Cleveland Foundation Strategy: Arts Mastery

As we discussed in our planning sessions, arts mastery in the context of not only curation but also in programming directed towards African American teens is likely niche programming. Curating is often framed and imagined as a job dependent on a high level of literacy in European/White art and is an elite position even among arts professionals. As a result, it is likely that without a dramatic change to the framing of the program, and maybe even with one, the program is likely going to appeal to young people who already have an arts background. In fact, of the 11 young people interviewed for this project, 7 described their prior arts learning history. This prior arts learning is not a factor specific to CMA, but rather one that shows up across the Arts Mastery Initiative. As a result, the program may want to think about how it might more explicitly make the case that it is wanting to diversify the arts museum field, partner with such organizations as Museum Hue and frame the program as one that is targeted to the more seasoned young artist, regardless of prior arts training.



CUC Successes

While we were not looking for stories of CUC success, we found 16 different instances of this dimension. Young people expressed surprise and excitement as they began to get a better sense of what it is that a museum does and holds.



"Looking back, like this was definitely a new type of education for me. I was looking to art curating. Um, I just think that's so interesting. Like I'd love to work at a museum and just like spend my days looking at different art and like reading the history of it and like putting it together and organizing it. I just feel like that'd be such a neat job. I don't know, like pretty recently, for awhile, I wanted to be a lawyer, but I realized like maybe an office job, like that is just not what I want to do. And then also I feel like the CMA program definitely, like, helped me think down that path a little bit more."

"I feel like my instructors were like super cool, super chill really inviting, and then somehow they can mostly make the right mix of people inside the program."



Conclusion

In terms of creating programming that speaks to the needs of Black and Brown creatives, their comments suggest that were the museum to place an increased focus on Black and Brown artists this would be appealing, but largely they are simply looking for a program that is welcoming and does not tokenize. The challenge may be that when it comes to mastery, the program will likely need to rely on young people who have previous arts experience and that they would like to be around young people similar to them in that regard. These factors, in turn, could lead to programming that remains a niche product rather than that could make claims to reaching tens of young people per term and so this is an issue for the foundation and CMA administration to continue to take into account in the case of CUC.

Thank you!

A very special thank you to Cullen, Deonta and Maya for all of your work and a just as special thank you to Sabine, Sydney and Darius. We wish you all the best!